10,000 BLACK INTERNS · CLASS OF 2027 · INDUSTRY GUIDE

Investment Management, Sales & Public Relations

From absolute zero to industry-expert understanding. Each industry is broken into its parts, with how it makes money, the terminology, the diagrams, and what's happening right now, so that what you write shows you know what you're talking about.

1 · Investment Management

Clients → Distribution & Sales → Investing → Support functions

2 · Sales

Lead generation → Closing → Account management → Sales operations

3 · Public Relations

Corporate & financial → Consumer → Crisis → Public affairs & internal

How to use: the contents page is clickable, and every page has a "↑ Contents" link in the top-right corner. Blue **Zero-knowledge** boxes explain the basics, and purple **Expert insight** boxes give you the nuance most candidates won't have. Figures are rounded and illustrative unless a source is given, so use them to understand rather than to quote. Prepared October 2026.

NAVIGATION

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Reading plan: read Part A first (about 20 minutes). Then read the whole industry for your **first** choice before you write that answer, and do the same for the other two. Finish each industry with its "Expert check". If you can answer those questions out loud without notes, you understand the industry better than almost everyone you're competing against.

A

Foundations

The handful of ideas every one of these industries assumes you already know. If you understand these four pages, nothing later will feel like jargon.

1. How any business works: revenue, cost, profit
2. Shares, bonds, interest rates and inflation
3. Risk, return, diversification and compounding
4. Customers, B2B vs B2C and regulation

A1 · How any business works

Every company, whether an asset manager, a software firm or a PR agency, does the same thing at heart: it sells something for more than it costs to provide.

Revenue
money coming in from customers

–

Costs
salaries, rent, tech, marketing

=

Profit
what's left for owners

ZERO-KNOWLEDGE EXPLAINER

Revenue (also "turnover", "sales" or "the top line") is the money a business earns from customers before any costs.

Profit ("the bottom line") is what remains after all costs.

Margin is profit as a percentage of revenue. £100 revenue and £30 profit is a **30% margin**. A high margin means each pound of revenue is very profitable.

ZERO-KNOWLEDGE EXPLAINER

Fixed costs stay the same however much you sell (e.g. office rent, core staff). **Variable costs** rise with each sale (e.g. materials, commission).

Scale is the idea that once fixed costs are covered, each extra sale is mostly profit. That's why big firms in all three industries chase growth.

Four ways any business can grow revenue

1. New customers
Win clients you didn't have

2. Sell more
To existing customers (upsell, cross-sell)

3. Charge more
Raise prices or sell premium products

4. Keep customers
Every client lost must be replaced

Keep these four in mind. Sales exists to do 1 and 2. Account management and client service exist to do 2 and 4. PR protects 3 and 4, because reputation lets you charge more and keeps customers loyal. Investment management is a special case: its revenue also grows when *markets* rise (see B10).

Front office, middle office, back office

You'll hear these phrases constantly in finance. They describe how close a team is to the client and to revenue:

Front office

- Generates revenue directly
- e.g. fund managers, salespeople, client relationship managers

Middle office

- Controls risk and checks the front office
- e.g. risk, compliance, performance measurement

Back office

- Processes and records everything
- e.g. operations, settlement, accounting, IT

Cost centre vs profit centre

A **profit centre** brings in revenue (e.g. a sales team or an investment team). A **cost centre** supports the business but doesn't bill anyone directly (e.g. HR, in-house PR, compliance). Cost centres must constantly *show* their value. That's why in-house PR teams measure coverage and reputation so carefully (D7).

A2 · Shares, bonds, interest rates and inflation

Companies and governments need money. They raise it in two basic ways: by selling a piece of ownership (**shares**) or by borrowing (**bonds**). Investors buy these to grow their savings.

Shares (equities, stocks)

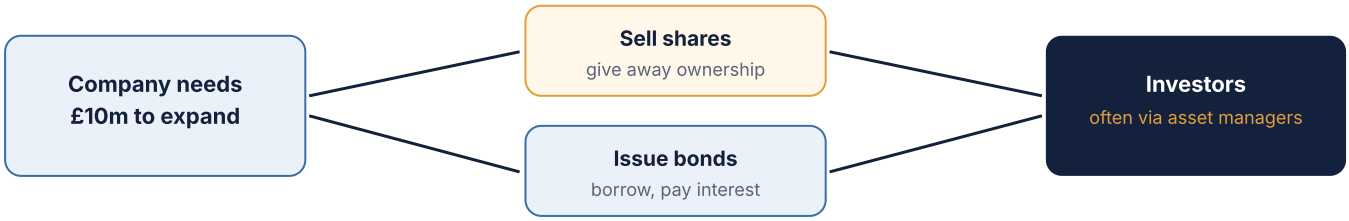
A share is a tiny slice of **ownership** in a company. If you own 1 share out of 1 million, you own one-millionth of the company.

- You make money if the **share price rises** (capital growth) or the company pays you a slice of its profit (a **dividend**).
- Higher potential return, but **higher risk**: if the company fails, shareholders are paid last and can lose everything.
- Bought and sold on a **stock exchange** (e.g. the London Stock Exchange). The FTSE 100 is an **index** of the 100 largest UK-listed companies.

Bonds (fixed income, debt)

A bond is a **loan** you make to a government or company. They promise to pay you interest (the **coupon**) and return your money on a set date (**maturity**).

- UK government bonds are called **gilts**. Company bonds are **corporate bonds**.
- Lower risk than shares, because bondholders are paid before shareholders. Returns are more predictable, hence "fixed income".
- **Credit rating** (AAA down to junk) shows how likely the borrower is to repay.



Interest rates

The **interest rate** is the price of borrowing money. In the UK, the **Bank of England** sets the "base rate", which influences every other rate in the economy. Remember four things:

- **Rates up** → borrowing costs more, saving pays more, and economic growth tends to slow.
- **Bond prices move opposite to interest rates.** If new bonds pay 5%, an old bond paying 2% is worth less, so its price falls. This is the single most-tested fixed income idea in interviews.
- Higher rates usually put pressure on share prices, because future profits are worth less today and companies pay more on their debt.
- The **yield** is the return you'd earn on a bond at today's price. When prices fall, yields rise.

Inflation

Inflation is the rate at which prices rise. Measured in the UK by **CPI**, it means that £100 today buys less next year. Central banks aim for about **2%**. It matters because cash sitting in a bank loses *real* value whenever interest is below inflation. **That is the core reason people invest at all**, and it's a powerful opening idea for an investment management answer.

Real return ≈ **Nominal return** (what you see) − **Inflation**

A savings account paying 3% when inflation is 4% gives a **−1%** real return. You are getting poorer slowly.

A3 · Risk, return, diversification and compounding

Risk and return go together

The most basic rule of investing is that **to earn a higher return, you must accept more risk**. Risk here means uncertainty: how much the value can swing, and the chance of losing money. A professional investor's job is not to avoid risk but to take the *right* risks, and be paid properly for them.



The risk–return ladder (illustrative). Higher bars mean more expected return over the long run, and more volatility and risk of loss along the way.

ZERO-KNOWLEDGE EXPLAINER

Volatility is how much an investment's price swings up and down. It's measured by **standard deviation**. A fund with 20% volatility swings much more than one with 5%.

Liquidity is how quickly you can sell something for cash without moving the price. Shares in big companies are very liquid. Property and private companies are **illiquid**, which can take months or years.

ZERO-KNOWLEDGE EXPLAINER

Time horizon is how long until you need the money. A 25-year-old saving for retirement can take more risk than a 64-year-old, because they have time to recover from falls.

Risk appetite (or tolerance) is how much loss a client can emotionally and financially accept. Matching investments to a client's horizon and appetite is the heart of client-facing work.

Diversification: "don't put all your eggs in one basket"

If you own one company and it fails, you lose everything. If you own 500 companies across countries and industries, one failure barely matters. **Diversification** reduces risk without necessarily reducing expected return. It's often called "the only free lunch in investing". It is why most people invest through **funds** (pooled portfolios of many investments) rather than buying individual shares.

Asset allocation means deciding how much to put in each asset type (e.g. 60% shares / 40% bonds). It is the biggest driver of a portfolio's long-run result, more than picking individual shares.

Compounding: why time matters so much

Compounding means earning returns on your previous returns. Growth snowballs:

£10,000 invested at 6% a year	After 10 years	After 20 years	After 40 years
Value	≈ £17,900	≈ £32,100	≈ £102,900

EXPERT INSIGHT

Small fee differences compound too. On a pension pot over 40 years, paying 1.0% a year instead of 0.2% can reduce the final value by roughly a quarter or more. That's why fees are so fiercely debated in investment management, and why regulators push firms to prove "value for money" (B12).

Active vs passive in one paragraph

Passive investing buys every company in an index (e.g. all of the FTSE 100) to match the market's return at very low cost. **Active** investing pays professionals to pick investments, aiming to **beat** the market, which is called generating **alpha**, for a higher fee. Much of the modern industry is shaped by the battle between the two (B13).

A4 · Customers, B2B vs B2C and regulation

B2B: business-to-business

- Selling to **organisations** (e.g. an asset manager selling to a pension fund, or software sold to a bank)
- Few customers, but each is worth a lot
- Many decision-makers, formal processes, long sales cycles (months)
- Relationships and trust are everything

B2C: business-to-consumer

- Selling to **individuals** (e.g. a fund sold to you via an app, or a supermarket product)
- Many customers, each worth relatively little
- Quick decisions, often emotional, driven by brand and marketing
- Scale and reputation are everything

There's also **B2B2C**, where you sell through an intermediary to the end customer. Asset managers selling funds through financial advisers and investment platforms (who then serve the public) is a classic example. That's called the **wholesale** or **intermediary** channel (B4).

Stakeholders

A **stakeholder** is anyone affected by, or able to affect, an organisation: customers, employees, shareholders/investors, regulators, government, suppliers, media and local communities. PR is essentially the management of relationships with stakeholders (D1).

Regulation: why finance is different

Because financial firms look after other people's money, they're tightly regulated. In the UK:

Body	What it does
FCA (Financial Conduct Authority)	Regulates how financial firms behave, including asset managers, advisers and banks' conduct. Protects consumers and market integrity. It can fine firms and ban individuals.
PRA (Prudential Regulation Authority)	Part of the Bank of England. Makes sure banks and insurers are financially safe (hold enough capital).
Bank of England	Sets interest rates and looks after overall financial stability.
The Pensions Regulator (TPR)	Oversees workplace pension schemes and their trustees.
CMA (Competition and Markets Authority)	Competition and consumer protection across all industries, including misleading "green" claims in marketing.
ASA (Advertising Standards Authority)	Rules on advertising and marketing honesty. Relevant to PR and sales.

Fiduciary duty

A **fiduciary** is someone legally obliged to act in another person's best interest. Asset managers and pension trustees have fiduciary-style duties to their clients. This idea, *"we look after other people's money and must put them first"*, sits underneath everything in investment management, and it is a strong theme to show you understand.

You now have the foundations. Revenue, profit, margin, shares, bonds, interest rates, inflation, risk, diversification, compounding, active/passive, B2B/B2C, stakeholders and regulation. Every later page builds on these. **Continue to Investment Management →**

B

Investment Management

Also called **asset management** or **fund management**. This is the business of investing other people's money (pensions, savings, insurance premiums) for a fee. It's your first choice and the 10,000 Black Interns programme's founding sector.

1. What it is
2. The ecosystem
3. The four parts
4. The clients
5. Distribution & sales
6. Asset classes
7. Investment process
8. Support functions
9. Products & vehicles
10. How it makes money
11. Landscape
12. Regulation
13. Trends
14. Glossary
15. Expert check

B1 · What investment management is

An **asset manager** takes money from many savers, pools it, and invests it in shares, bonds, property and other assets, aiming to grow it in line with each client's goals. In return it charges a small yearly percentage of the money it looks after.

ZERO-KNOWLEDGE EXPLAINER

Analogy: imagine 10,000 people each have £1,000 to save. On their own, none can afford a professional or buy enough different investments to be safe. Pooled together they have £10 million. They can now hire a team of experts, own hundreds of companies, and pay each expert a tiny fraction of the pot. That pooled pot is a **fund**, and the firm running it is an **asset manager**.

Where the money actually comes from

Most people never deal with an asset manager directly, but almost everyone in the UK is a client indirectly:



Why it matters (your "why" material)

For savers: it's how ordinary people beat inflation and afford retirement. The quality of investment decisions directly affects how millions of people live in old age.

For the economy: it channels savings into companies, infrastructure and governments that need capital to grow. This is called **capital allocation**.

For companies: as shareholders, asset managers vote and engage with company boards on strategy, pay and climate. This is called **stewardship**.

Scale

The UK is the world's second-largest asset management centre after the US. The Investment Association reports roughly **£9 trillion** managed in the UK. Globally, the industry manages well over **$100 trillion**. The largest firm, BlackRock, manages more than $10 trillion on its own.

Buy-side vs sell-side

Buy-side means firms that **buy** investments with clients' money: asset managers, hedge funds, private equity, pension funds and insurers. You are buy-side.

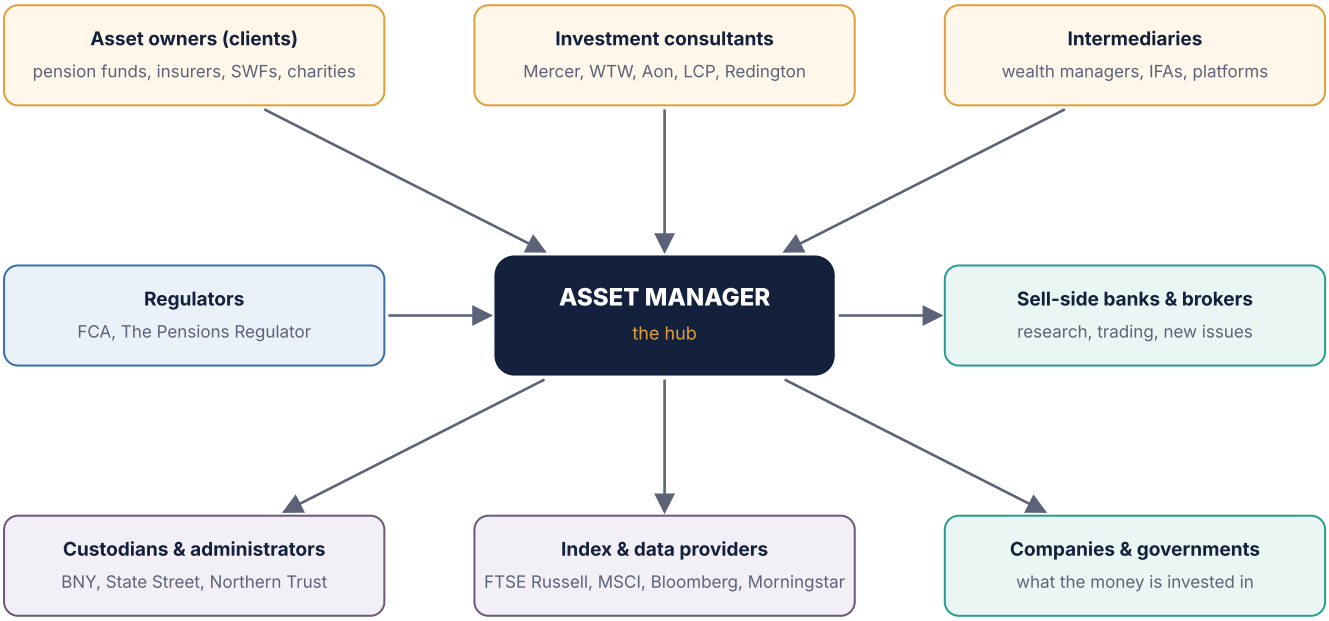
Sell-side means investment banks and brokers that **sell** services to the buy-side, such as research, trading, and new shares or bonds. Their clients are the buy-side.

EXPERT INSIGHT

Asset managers and **wealth managers** are related but different. An asset manager builds funds and portfolios, usually for institutions or for sale through intermediaries. A wealth manager works with individual (often wealthy) clients on their whole financial picture and often *buys* asset managers' funds for those clients. In other words, wealth managers are often an asset manager's **client**.

B2 · The ecosystem: who's who

An asset manager sits in the middle of a web of other organisations. Knowing who each one is, and what they want, is what separates an expert from a beginner.



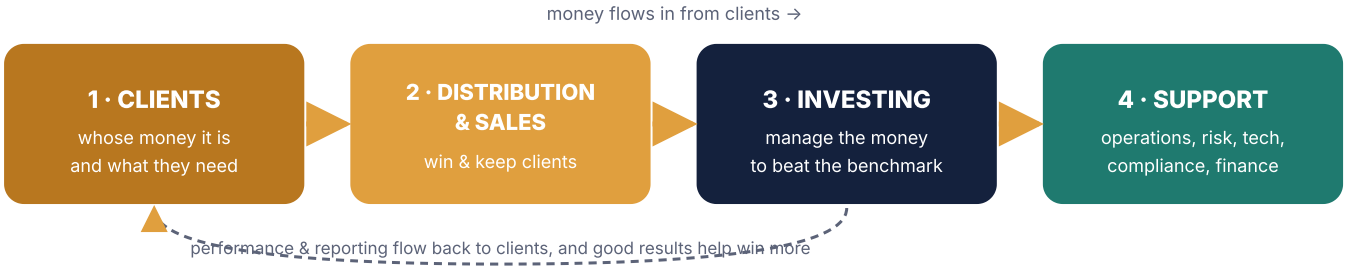
Player	Role	What they want from the asset manager
Asset owners	Own the money: pension schemes, insurers, sovereign wealth funds (SWFs), endowments	Returns that meet their liabilities, low fees, trust and transparency
Investment consultants	Advise asset owners (especially pension trustees) on strategy and **which managers to hire**. They "rate" managers.	Detailed data, a consistent process, quick answers. They are **gatekeepers**.
Intermediaries	Wealth managers, financial advisers (IFAs) and platforms that pick funds for individuals	Good funds for their "buy lists", strong servicing, and support explaining funds to their clients
Sell-side	Banks providing research, trade execution and new bond or share issues	Trading business (commissions) and investor demand for new issues
Custodians	Safely hold the actual assets and keep records; fund administrators calculate fund prices	Accurate instructions and data
Index & data providers	Create benchmarks (FTSE 100, MSCI World), ratings (Morningstar stars) and data	Licence fees. Their ratings influence fund sales.
Regulators	Set and enforce rules (FCA)	Fair treatment of clients, good governance, honest marketing

EXPERT INSIGHT

Consultants are the hidden power in UK institutional sales. A pension scheme's trustees are often volunteers or part-timers. They rely on a consultant like Mercer or WTW to shortlist managers. If a consultant doesn't rate your fund, you'll rarely win that scheme. That's why asset managers have whole **consultant relations** teams (B5).

B3 · The four parts of an asset manager

Every asset manager, from a 20-person boutique to a global giant, can be understood as four connected parts.



1 · Clients

- Institutional (pensions, insurers)
- Wholesale (wealth managers, advisers, platforms)
- Retail (individuals)

Key idea: each client type buys differently and wants different things.

2 · Distribution & sales

- Sales / business development
- Client relationship management
- Consultant relations
- Product specialists
- RFP team, marketing, product

Goal: grow AUM through new money and keep existing clients.

3 · Investing

- Portfolio managers
- Research analysts
- Dealers / traders
- Economists, strategists
- Stewardship

Goal: deliver returns that meet client objectives within risk limits.

4 · Support functions

- Operations
- Risk & performance
- Compliance & legal
- Technology & data
- Finance, HR

Goal: run everything accurately, safely and within the rules.

How the parts depend on each other

If this part fails...	...this happens
Investing underperforms	Clients leave (outflows), consultants downgrade the fund, and sales get much harder
Distribution is weak	Even a great fund doesn't grow. Many excellent funds stay small because nobody sells them well.
Client service slips	Clients leave even when performance is fine. Trust is lost in a bad meeting or a wrong report.
Operations or compliance fail	Pricing errors, regulatory fines, reputational damage and, in the worst case, closure

EXPERT INSIGHT

Industry insiders say **"funds are bought, not sold"** for institutions, because the decision is formal and evidence-based. Yet they also say **"the best-performing fund doesn't always win; the best-explained one often does."** Both are true. That tension is exactly why the client-facing side is a skilled job: you must translate investment performance into confidence.

B4 · Part 1: The clients

Asset managers split clients into three **channels**. Each one is a different market with different buyers, sales cycles and needs.

1 Institutional

Who: organisations investing large sums for a defined purpose.

Ticket size: tens of millions to billions

Decides: trustees or investment committees, usually advised by a consultant

Cares about: meeting liabilities, risk control, fees, governance, ESG, reporting

2 Wholesale / intermediary

Who: professionals who pick funds *for* individual clients.

Ticket size: thousands to tens of millions per firm

Decides: fund selectors and research teams at wealth managers and platforms

Cares about: consistent performance, a clear story, cost, and support materials for their clients

3 Retail / direct

Who: individuals investing themselves, via apps and platforms.

Ticket size: small, but millions of people

Decides: the individual, influenced by brand, ratings, media and price

Cares about: simplicity, trust, low cost and good outcomes (FCA Consumer Duty)

Institutional clients in detail

Client	What they are	What they need
Defined benefit (DB) pension schemes	Pay members a guaranteed income in retirement based on salary. The scheme (and employer) carries the risk. Most UK private DB schemes are now closed to new members.	Certainty of meeting future payments. Heavy use of **LDI** (liability-driven investment) and bonds. Many aim for a "buyout" with an insurer.
Defined contribution (DC) pensions	Your pot depends on what's paid in plus investment returns. Run by master trusts (e.g. Nest, L&G, Aviva) and providers. **The big growth market.**	Low-cost, long-term growth via a "default fund" for members who never choose. Increasingly, some private markets.
Local Government Pension Scheme (LGPS)	The pension for council and public-sector workers in England & Wales. It's funded and being merged into fewer, larger **pools**.	Scale, low costs, and investment in UK and local projects
Insurers	Invest premiums so they can pay future claims and annuities	Steady income (lots of bonds) and meeting capital rules
Sovereign wealth funds (SWFs)	State-owned investment funds (e.g. Norway's, Abu Dhabi's, Singapore's GIC)	Very long-term growth. Huge mandates. Very demanding.
Endowments & foundations	Universities and charities investing gifts so they can fund their work forever	Real returns of inflation + 4–5% to spend sustainably; ethical restrictions

Wholesale clients in detail

Wealth managers / private banks manage portfolios for wealthy individuals (e.g. St James's Place, Rathbones, Coutts). **Discretionary fund managers (DFMs)** can make investment decisions for clients without asking each time.

IFAs (independent financial advisers) give regulated advice to individuals and recommend funds.

Platforms are online "supermarkets" for funds (e.g. Hargreaves Lansdown, AJ Bell, interactive investor). Being on their **best-buy list** can drive huge flows.

Fund of funds / multi-managers build portfolios out of other managers' funds.

Fund selectors are the analysts at these firms who decide which funds make the "buy list". They are the key buyers.

EXPERT INSIGHT

DB vs DC is the most useful distinction to drop into an answer. DB is shrinking and "de-risking" (buying bonds, then transferring to insurers through buyouts). DC is growing fast, because auto-enrolment since 2012 put millions of workers into pensions. Asset managers are shifting resources towards DC and wealth accordingly.

B5 · Part 2: Distribution & sales

"Distribution" is the asset management word for everything involved in **winning, keeping and growing client money**. It's the client-facing side, and the part most directly tied to revenue.

The teams

Team / role	What they do	What an intern might do
Institutional sales / business development (BD)	Hunt for new institutional clients and mandates; build relationships with prospects and consultants; lead pitches	Research prospects, update the CRM, prepare pitch books, sit in on meetings
Wholesale / intermediary sales	Cover wealth managers, IFAs and platforms; get funds onto buy lists; often regionally based (e.g. "Scotland & North")	Prepare meeting materials, analyse which clients hold which funds
Client relationship management (CRM) / client directors	"Farmers": own existing clients, run review meetings, spot needs, defend against losses, cross-sell	Prepare quarterly review packs, take notes, track client requests
Consultant relations	Manage relationships with investment consultants who shortlist managers, and fill in their research databases	Update consultant databases, compile performance data
Product specialists / investment directors	Experts on a strategy who explain it to clients in depth: the bridge between portfolio managers and clients	Draft market commentary, update presentations and factsheets
RFP / proposals team	Write formal answers to Requests for Proposal and due diligence questionnaires (DDQs)	Update the answer library, draft standard sections
Client service / reporting	Onboarding, accurate client reports, day-to-day queries	Check reports, reconcile data, handle simple queries
Marketing & product	Brand, campaigns, thought leadership, events; designing and launching new funds	Content drafts, event support, competitor analysis

How an institutional mandate is won (the sales cycle)

1 · Profile — Build a relationship with the consultant; get the strategy **rated**

› **2 · Search** — The scheme decides to hire; the consultant runs a manager search

› **3 · RFP** — Long questionnaire on team, process, performance, fees, ESG, risk

› **4 · Shortlist** — Usually 3–5 managers make the "finals"

› **5 · Finals pitch** — Present to trustees; Q&A; fee negotiation

› **6 · Onboard** — Legal agreements (IMA), transfer assets, set up reporting

› **7 · Retain** — Quarterly reviews and years of servicing

This cycle typically takes 6–18 months. Wholesale is faster: get a meeting → present → due diligence → buy list → ongoing support.

How distribution is measured

Net flows / net new money
Inflows minus outflows. The headline sales number.

Retention rate
The share of clients and AUM kept each year

Pipeline
The value of prospects at each stage of the cycle

Win rate / revenue
Finals won, and fee revenue added

EXPERT INSIGHT

Why retention is the most important (and underrated) number. Winning a new £500m mandate takes perhaps a year of work. Losing one can happen in a single bad meeting. Each lost client must be replaced just to stand still. Strong client relationship teams protect the revenue base, and that is the core argument for why the client-facing side matters as much as investment performance.

B6 · Part 3: Investing, the asset classes

An **asset class** is a group of investments that behave similarly. Asset managers organise their investment teams around them. You need to know the main ones and what each is *for*.

Asset class	What it is	Role in a portfolio	Risk / liquidity
Equities	Shares in listed companies. Split by region (UK, US, global, emerging markets), size (large, small cap) and style (growth, value)	Long-term growth	Higher risk; very liquid
Fixed income	Bonds: government (gilts, Treasuries), investment-grade corporate, high-yield ("junk"), emerging-market debt	Income and stability; protection in downturns	Lower to medium; mostly liquid
Multi-asset	Funds that combine equities, bonds and others, adjusting the mix over time	A one-stop diversified solution	Medium
Cash / money markets	Very short-term loans to governments and banks	Safety and liquidity	Very low
Real estate	Commercial property: offices, warehouses, shops, housing	Income, inflation link, diversification	Medium; illiquid
Infrastructure	Roads, airports, energy networks, wind farms, data centres	Long-term stable income, often inflation-linked	Medium; illiquid
Private equity	Buying whole private companies, improving them, then selling after 3–7 years	High long-term growth	High; very illiquid
Private credit	Lending directly to companies instead of through banks	Higher income than bonds	Medium–high; illiquid
Hedge funds	Flexible strategies that can bet on prices falling ("shorting") and use leverage	Returns that don't depend on markets rising	Varies; often less liquid

Public vs private markets

Public markets: traded on exchanges, with prices every second, high transparency and easy buying and selling. This is where traditional asset managers grew up.

Private markets: not exchange-traded and valued only occasionally. Money is locked up for years, but there is potential for higher returns and fees. This is the **fastest-growing area** of the industry, and traditional managers are racing to build or buy capabilities (B13).

Investment styles

Active: picks investments to beat a benchmark, for higher fees

Passive / index: tracks a benchmark at very low cost

Growth: companies expected to grow fast (e.g. tech), often expensive

Value: companies that look cheap relative to their worth

Income: companies or bonds paying high, steady dividends or coupons

Quantitative ("quant"): investment decisions driven by data and models

Fundamental: deep research into individual companies' businesses

Top-down vs bottom-up: start from the economy vs start from individual companies

Sustainable / ESG: considers environmental, social and governance factors

Smart beta / factor: rules-based funds tilted to factors like value or quality, a hybrid of active and passive

EXPERT INSIGHT

Ask any portfolio manager "what's your process?" and you'll hear a version of: *philosophy* (what we believe drives returns) → *process* (how we find and choose investments) → *portfolio construction* (how we size positions and control risk). Consultants judge managers on whether these three are clear, consistent and repeatable. Using that language shows real understanding.

B7 · Part 3: The investment process, and how performance is judged

The investment process, step by step

1 · Mandate
Client objective, benchmark, risk limits and restrictions are agreed

›

2 · Ideas
Analysts screen and research companies, bonds and themes

›

3 · Research
Financial models, meetings with management, valuation

›

4 · Decide
The portfolio manager chooses what to own and how much

›

5 · Risk check
Risk and compliance confirm limits are respected

›

6 · Execute
Dealers trade in the market at the best price

›

7 · Monitor
Review positions; report performance to clients

The investment team roles

Portfolio manager (PM) / fund manager
Makes the final investment decisions and is accountable for the fund's performance. Often meets major clients.

Research analyst
Covers a sector (e.g. banks, healthcare) or region and recommends buys and sells. "Buy-side analyst" is a common entry route.

Dealer / trader
Executes trades efficiently and quietly, so big orders don't push the price against the fund.

Economist / strategist
Views on the economy, interest rates and asset allocation.

Stewardship / responsible investment
Votes at company meetings and engages boards on governance, climate and pay.

Investment risk
Measures and challenges the risks the PM takes. Independent from the PM.

How performance is judged

Benchmark: the index a fund is compared with (e.g. MSCI World, FTSE All-Share)

Absolute return: how much the fund made (e.g. +8%)

Relative return / excess return: versus the benchmark (fund +8%, benchmark +6% = +2%)

Alpha: return from the manager's skill, above what the market delivered

Beta: how much a fund moves with the market. Beta 1 = moves in line.

Tracking error: how far a fund's returns drift from its benchmark (a risk measure for active funds)

Sharpe ratio: return per unit of risk taken. Higher is better.

Drawdown: the fall from a peak to a trough. Clients remember big drawdowns.

Peer group / quartile: how the fund ranks against similar funds. "Top quartile" means the best 25%.

Track record: performance history. Consultants usually want 3–5+ years.

A worked example

A global equity fund returns **+11%** this year. Its benchmark, the MSCI World, returned **+9%**. The fund charges 0.75%. Net of fees, the client got roughly +10.25%, an excess return of about **+1.25%**. The client relationship manager's job at the review meeting is to explain *why* (which decisions added value, and which detracted) and whether the process should keep working. If the fund had returned +11% while the benchmark did +14%, the conversation would be about **underperformance**, even though the client made money.

EXPERT INSIGHT

Performance attribution breaks down *where* excess return came from: asset allocation (being in the right markets) vs stock selection (picking the right companies). Client-facing teams use attribution reports in every review meeting. Knowing the term signals that you understand what client conversations actually involve.

B8 · Part 4: Support functions & the trade lifecycle

Often more than half of an asset manager's staff work outside investing and sales. These teams keep the firm accurate, safe and legal. Many great careers start here, and an intern who understands them stands out.

Function	What it does	Why it matters
Investment operations	Processes and settles trades, reconciles positions with the custodian, handles corporate actions (dividends, mergers)	An unsettled or wrong trade costs money and trust
Fund accounting / administration	Calculates each fund's daily price (the **NAV**, net asset value), often outsourced to administrators	Investors buy and sell at the NAV, so it must be right
Risk management	Independent oversight of investment, liquidity, counterparty and operational risk	Prevents blow-ups. Regulators require it.
Performance & analytics	Calculates returns and attribution for every portfolio	Feeds every client report and pitch
Compliance	Makes sure the firm follows FCA rules; checks marketing materials; monitors personal trading	Breaches mean fines and bans
Legal	Fund documents, client contracts (investment management agreements), regulation	Protects the firm and clients
Technology & data	Trading systems (e.g. Aladdin, Charles River), data platforms, cyber security, AI tools	Efficiency, and a growing competitive edge
Finance, HR, corporate	The firm's own accounts, people, strategy, M&A	Running the business itself

The trade lifecycle: what happens when a PM buys a share

PM decides
"Buy 1m shares of Company X"

›

Pre-trade compliance
The system checks fund rules and limits automatically

›

Dealer executes
Trades via brokers or electronic venues

›

Confirmation
Both sides confirm the price and quantity

›

Settlement
Cash and shares swap via the custodian (UK shares: T+1 from October 2027, currently T+2)

›

Reconcile & report
Records matched; the NAV and client reports updated

"T+2" means settlement two business days after the trade date. The UK plans to move to T+1 in October 2027, following the US (May 2024).

Outsourcing

Many asset managers outsource custody, fund administration and some operations to large providers (e.g. BNY, State Street, Northern Trust, HSBC). They keep "oversight" teams to supervise them. This is part of the industry's response to **cost pressure** (B13).

EXPERT INSIGHT

If you're allocated to a role in operations rather than the client side, don't treat it as second best. Client service and reporting teams depend completely on operations data, and understanding the plumbing makes you a far better client-facing professional later. Saying in an interview that you understand *how the client report gets made* is rare and valued.

B9 · Products and fund vehicles

The **strategy** is *what* the manager does (e.g. "global equity income"). The **vehicle** is the legal wrapper clients buy it through. One strategy can be sold in several vehicles to different clients.

Pooled funds (many investors share one portfolio)

- **OEIC / unit trust:** UK open-ended funds. Investors buy and sell at the daily NAV, and the fund grows or shrinks with demand.
- **UCITS:** the EU standard for retail funds, sellable across Europe (often Dublin or Luxembourg "SICAVs"). A strong investor-protection badge.
- **ETF (exchange-traded fund):** a fund that trades on a stock exchange like a share. Usually passive and cheap. A fast-growing vehicle.
- **Investment trust:** a UK company listed on the stock exchange that invests in other assets. Its shares can trade above (premium) or below (discount) the value of its assets.
- **LTAF (Long-Term Asset Fund):** a UK vehicle (since 2021) designed to let DC pensions access illiquid private assets.

Segregated mandates (one client, own portfolio)

A large client (e.g. a £1bn pension scheme) has a portfolio run just for them, with custom restrictions (e.g. no tobacco) and negotiated fees. Governed by an **investment management agreement (IMA)**.

Private market funds

Closed-ended limited partnerships. Investors commit money that's "called" over time, locked up for 7–12 years, with fees on committed capital plus **carried interest**. The terms are **GP** (general partner, the manager) and **LP** (limited partner, the investor).

Model portfolios

Ready-made portfolios that wealth managers and advisers use for their clients. A big growth area in wholesale.

Open-ended vs closed-ended

	Open-ended (OEIC, unit trust, most UCITS, ETFs)	Closed-ended (investment trusts, private equity funds)
Size	Grows and shrinks as investors come and go	Fixed pool of capital
Liquidity	Daily dealing at NAV	Sell shares on an exchange (trusts) or wait until the fund ends (PE)
Best for	Liquid assets: listed shares and bonds	Illiquid assets: property, private companies, infrastructure
Danger	A "liquidity mismatch" if it holds illiquid assets but promises daily dealing	Trading at a discount when sentiment is poor

EXPERT INSIGHT

The 2019 Woodford case is the classic lesson. The Woodford Equity Income Fund was a daily-dealing open-ended fund that held hard-to-sell unlisted companies. When performance fell, investors rushed to withdraw, and the fund had to **suspend** dealing in June 2019, trapping investors. It then wound down. It's cited constantly as an example of liquidity mismatch, of reputational collapse, and of why the FCA scrutinises fund structures. It's useful in IM *and* PR conversations.

Share classes and charges

One fund can have several **share classes** with different fees (e.g. a retail class, a cheaper "clean" class for platforms, and an institutional class for big investors). Retail funds show an **OCF** (ongoing charges figure): the annual cost as a percentage, including the management fee and running costs. Under the PRIIPs and UK consumer rules, investors must also receive standardised documents showing costs and risks (e.g. a KID / KIID).

B10 · How an asset manager makes money

Revenue per year = **Average AUM** assets under management × **Fee rate** in basis points (bps) + **Performance fees** some products only

ZERO-KNOWLEDGE EXPLAINER

Basis points: 1 bp = 0.01%. So 100 bps = 1%, and a 45 bps fee = 0.45% a year. On £1 billion, 45 bps = **£4.5 million a year**. Fees are taken automatically from the fund, usually daily or monthly, so the client doesn't write a cheque.

AUM changes for only two reasons

AUM end of year = **AUM start** + **Market movement** investment performance + **Net flows** new money − withdrawals

So an asset manager's revenue depends on **markets** (partly outside its control), **performance** (the investment team) and **flows** (the distribution team). This is why asset manager share prices rise and fall with the stock market, and why firms obsess over net flows.

A simple P&L for a mid-sized manager (illustrative)

Line	£m	Notes
Average AUM: £50bn at an average fee of 40 bps		
Management fee revenue	**200**	£50bn × 0.40%
Performance fees	10	Volatile, so investors value it less
Staff costs (salaries + bonuses)	(95)	The biggest cost, often around half of revenue
Technology, data, premises, distribution, other	(55)	Data and tech costs rising fast
Operating profit	**60**	**Operating margin ≈ 29%**

Operating margin (operating profit ÷ revenue) and the **cost/income ratio** (costs ÷ revenue, here about 71%) are how analysts judge asset managers. A cost/income ratio above 75–80% usually means a firm is under pressure.

Fee levels by product (typical, rough)

Product	Typical annual fee	Why
Passive index fund / ETF	0.03% – 0.25%	Automated, commoditised, competing on price
Active bonds, institutional	0.15% – 0.40%	Big clients negotiate
Active equities, institutional	0.35% – 0.75%	More research required
Active funds, retail / wholesale	0.60% – 1.00% (OCF)	Smaller tickets, more servicing and distribution cost
Hedge funds	~1–2% + ~15–20% of profits	Performance-based
Private equity / private credit	~1–2% + ~10–20% carried interest	Specialist, labour-intensive, long lock-ups

EXPERT INSIGHT

Why scale matters so much: managing £100bn doesn't need twice the people of £50bn. Extra AUM is mostly profit, which is why the industry is consolidating. But fees are falling ("fee compression") as clients move to passive and negotiate harder. So firms face a squeeze: revenue per £ is falling while tech, data and regulatory costs rise. Explaining that squeeze in one sentence is a strong signal of understanding.

B11 · The industry landscape

The Investment Management workstream could match you to any of these kinds of firm. Knowing the types means you won't be surprised whoever calls.

Type	What makes them different	UK-relevant examples
Global giants	Huge scale, often strong in passive / ETFs, every asset class	BlackRock, Vanguard, State Street, Fidelity International, J.P. Morgan AM, Amundi
UK-headquartered majors	Large active and multi-asset ranges; strong UK pension and wholesale presence	Legal & General (LGIM), Schroders, M&G, abrdn (aberdeen), Aviva Investors, Royal London AM, Baillie Gifford, Columbia Threadneedle, Ninety One, Jupiter
Insurer / bank-owned	The investment arm of a larger group, managing group money plus external clients	Aviva Investors, M&G, HSBC AM, Insight (BNY), Federated Hermes
Boutiques	Small, specialist and often partner-owned. Interns see more of the business.	Many: Artemis, Liontrust, Polar Capital, Ruffer, Troy and others
Alternatives	Hedge funds, private equity, private credit, real estate	Man Group, Capstone, Permira, CVC, Ares, ICG, Partners Group, Blackstone
Wealth managers	Individual clients; often buy other managers' funds	St James's Place, Rathbones, Brewin/RBC, Quilter, Canaccord, Evelyn
Asset owners with in-house teams	Pension funds or pools that manage money themselves	USS, Border to Coast, Railpen, LGPS pools, Nest (the government-backed DC scheme)

Examples are for orientation only. They are not a list of 10,000 Black Interns hosts.

Where the jobs are

London is the dominant hub: the City, Canary Wharf, Mayfair (hedge funds and PE).

Edinburgh is a major second centre (Baillie Gifford, abrdn, many others), and **Glasgow** is growing in operations.

Manchester, Leeds, Birmingham, Bristol and Bournemouth have wealth managers, operations centres and pension providers.

Industry bodies worth knowing

The Investment Association (IA): trade body for UK asset managers. Publishes industry data and sector classifications.

CFA Institute / CFA Society UK: the main investment qualification (CFA charter), plus the IMC (Investment Management Certificate), a common UK entry exam

Diversity Project: industry initiative on diversity in investment and savings

Pensions UK (formerly the PLSA): trade body for pension schemes

BVCA: British Private Equity & Venture Capital Association (a 10K partner)

UK Stewardship Code: standards for how investors engage with companies, overseen by the FRC

EXPERT INSIGHT

Qualifications as conversation points: the **IMC** is the standard UK entry-level exam many graduates take in their first year. The **CFA** (three levels) is the gold standard for investment roles. The **CISI** runs exams common in wealth and operations. Mentioning that you're aware of the IMC, or have started studying it, is a concrete signal of commitment.

B12 · Regulation you should know

You don't need to be a lawyer, but knowing these by name and purpose shows maturity. Each is a one-line idea:

Rule / regime	What it does, in plain English
FCA authorisation	Every UK asset manager must be authorised by the FCA, and key individuals must be approved
Consumer Duty (from July 2023)	Firms must deliver **good outcomes** for retail customers: fair value, understandable communications, suitable products and proper support. A huge focus for retail and wholesale distribution and marketing.
Value for money / assessment of value	UK fund boards must annually assess whether each fund gives value for its fees. A growing value-for-money framework applies to DC pensions too.
SM&CR (Senior Managers & Certification Regime)	Named senior individuals are personally accountable for areas of the business
MiFID II (UK version)	Rules on investor protection, transparency, best execution and how research is paid for
UCITS / AIFMD	Rules for retail funds (UCITS) and alternative funds (AIFMD): diversification, liquidity, depositaries
SDR (Sustainability Disclosure Requirements)	The FCA's rules on sustainability labels for funds (e.g. "Sustainability Focus") and an **anti-greenwashing rule**: claims must be fair, clear and not misleading
Financial promotions rules	Marketing must be fair, clear and not misleading, and approved by compliance. This directly affects client-facing and marketing teams.
Market abuse (UK MAR)	Bans insider dealing and market manipulation. Staff can't trade on confidential information.
Anti-money laundering (AML) / KYC	"Know your customer": verifying clients' identity and source of funds during onboarding

Why regulation matters for the client side

Every factsheet, presentation, email campaign and social post that a distribution or marketing team produces must pass **compliance sign-off** as a financial promotion. Under Consumer Duty, firms must **evidence** that customers understand what they're buying. Good client-facing people write clearly, simply and accurately. That's a skill you can claim and demonstrate in your 250 words.

EXPERT INSIGHT

The phrase regulators and the industry use constantly is **"good outcomes"**. If you can say that a role "helps make sure clients understand what they own and get good outcomes", you are speaking the industry's current language.

B13 · What's happening now: key trends

Pick **one** of these for your answer and understand it deeply. The others are interview ammunition.

1 · The passive shift and fee compression

Cheap index funds and ETFs keep winning money from active funds, especially in equities. Average fees are falling. Active managers must prove they're worth paying for, through performance, specialist strategies or better client solutions.

So what for the client side: explaining value clearly has never mattered more.

2 · Private markets go mainstream

Private equity, private credit and infrastructure are growing much faster than traditional funds and carry higher fees. Traditional managers are buying private-markets firms or partnering with them. New vehicles (LTAFs, ELTIFs, semi-liquid "evergreen" funds) open them to DC pensions and wealthy individuals.

So what: lots of client education, because these products are complex and illiquid.

3 · UK pension reform

Government reforms (including the Pension Schemes Bill) push DC schemes to consolidate into fewer "megafunds" with large minimum sizes by around 2030, and LGPS assets into fewer, bigger pools. Under the 2025 **Mansion House Accord**, major DC providers pledged to put 10% of default funds into private markets by 2030, with at least half of that in the UK.

So what: fewer, larger, more sophisticated clients. Distribution becomes more consultative and the competition fiercer.

4 · Consolidation and cost pressure

Squeezed margins drive mergers, partnerships and job cuts. Firms outsource operations and invest in technology. Mid-sized active managers feel the most pressure, caught between giant passive firms and specialist boutiques.

So what: firms want people who add value quickly, can use technology and understand clients.

5 · Wealth and DC as the growth engines

Money is shifting from DB schemes to individuals: DC pots, ISAs and wealth managers. Model portfolios, platforms and digital investing are growing. The government also wants more people to invest rather than hold cash (e.g. ISA reforms announced in 2025).

So what: retail and wholesale distribution, plus Consumer Duty, matter more each year.

6 · Sustainability: still important, now more nuanced

ESG went through a boom, then a backlash (especially in the US) and greater scrutiny of "greenwashing". UK SDR labels now set standards. Clients still ask detailed questions about stewardship, climate and voting.

So what: you need precise, evidence-based communication, not slogans.

7 · AI and data

AI is used to summarise research, draft RFPs, personalise client reporting, analyse data and automate operations. Firms are investing heavily but carefully, because of accuracy and compliance concerns.

So what: entry-level work is changing. Judgement, relationships and checking AI output become more valuable.

8 · ETFs and tokenisation

Active ETFs (active strategies in an ETF wrapper) are growing fast, and Europe is catching up with the US. Some firms are experimenting with **tokenised** funds recorded on blockchain to speed up settlement.

So what: product and distribution teams are rethinking how funds reach investors.

EXPERT INSIGHT

A one-sentence synthesis you can adapt: *"As fee pressure, the growth of passive investing and pension consolidation create fewer, larger and more demanding clients, the firms that win will be those that can explain their value clearly and build long-term trust."* That sentence links three trends to why client-facing work matters.

B14 · Investment Management glossary

Active management: choosing investments to beat a benchmark

Alpha: return above the benchmark from skill

Asset allocation: the split between asset classes

Asset owner: the organisation that owns the money (e.g. a pension fund)

AUM: assets under management, the money a firm manages

Basis point (bp): 0.01%

Benchmark: the index a fund is measured against

Beta: sensitivity to market movements

Bond / gilt: a loan to a company / the UK government

Buy list: a wealth manager's or platform's approved funds

Buy-side / sell-side: investors / banks serving investors

Carried interest: a PE manager's share of profits

Consultant: an adviser who helps institutions choose managers

Custodian: the bank that holds the assets safely

DB / DC: defined benefit / defined contribution pensions

DDQ: due diligence questionnaire

Default fund: where DC savers' money goes if they don't choose

DFM: discretionary fund manager

Dividend: a share of profit paid to shareholders

Drawdown: peak-to-trough fall in value

Duration: a bond's sensitivity to interest rate changes

ESG: environmental, social, governance

ETF: exchange-traded fund

Fiduciary: obliged to act in the client's best interest

Fund selector: the analyst who picks funds for a buy list

IFA: independent financial adviser

IMA: investment management agreement (the contract)

Inflows / outflows: money coming in / leaving

Institutional: clients that are organisations

Investment trust: a listed closed-ended fund

LDI: liability-driven investment for DB schemes

LGPS: Local Government Pension Scheme

Liquidity: how easily something can be sold

LTAF: Long-Term Asset Fund (UK, for illiquid assets)

Mandate: the instruction and portfolio a client gives a manager

Master trust: a multi-employer DC pension scheme

NAV: net asset value, a fund's price per unit

Net flows: inflows minus outflows

OCF: ongoing charges figure (total annual cost)

OEIC / unit trust: UK open-ended funds

Passive: tracking an index

Performance attribution: explaining where returns came from

Pipeline: prospective business at each stage

Platform: an online fund supermarket

Portfolio manager (PM): makes investment decisions

Private markets: PE, private credit, infrastructure, real estate

Product specialist: explains strategies to clients

Quartile: ranking vs peers (1st = top 25%)

Rebalancing: resetting a portfolio back to its target mix

RFP / RFI: request for proposal / information

Segregated mandate: a bespoke portfolio for one client

Sharpe ratio: return per unit of risk

Share class: a version of a fund with different fees

Stewardship: voting and engaging with companies

SWF: sovereign wealth fund

Tracking error: how far returns deviate from the benchmark

Trustee: a person responsible for running a pension scheme

UCITS: the EU retail fund standard

Volatility: how much prices swing

Wholesale / intermediary: selling via advisers and wealth managers

Yield: income return on an investment

B15 · Expert check: can you answer these out loud?

If you can answer each in two or three sentences without notes, you understand investment management better than most applicants. A short model answer is given for each.

1. **How does an asset manager make money?**
   A percentage fee on assets under management, sometimes plus performance fees. Revenue grows through market performance and net flows, and costs are mainly people and technology.

2. **What's the difference between institutional and wholesale clients?**
   Institutional clients are organisations such as pension schemes and insurers, investing large sums, usually via consultants and RFPs. Wholesale clients are intermediaries such as wealth managers, IFAs and platforms that select funds for individuals.

3. **Why do investment consultants matter?**
   They advise pension trustees and shortlist managers, acting as gatekeepers. Without a positive consultant rating, winning institutional business is very difficult.

4. **What's the difference between DB and DC pensions, and why does it matter?**
   DB guarantees an income and the scheme bears the risk. Most are closed and de-risking. In DC, members bear the risk. DC is growing fast and consolidating, so it's a key growth market.

5. **Active vs passive: what's the debate?**
   Passive is cheaper and many active funds fail to beat their benchmark after fees, so money has moved to passive. Active managers argue for skill, risk management and access to areas passive can't reach, such as private markets.

6. **Why might interest rates rising hurt bond prices?**
   Existing bonds pay fixed coupons. When new bonds offer higher rates, old ones become less attractive, so their prices fall until their yield matches the market.

7. **What does a client relationship manager actually do?**
   Owns existing client relationships: runs review meetings explaining performance and positioning, handles requests, anticipates needs, and protects and grows the firm's revenue by retaining and expanding mandates.

8. **Name a current industry trend and why it matters.**
   E.g. UK pension consolidation: fewer, bigger schemes with more bargaining power and interest in private markets, which raises the bar for distribution teams.

9. **What is Consumer Duty?**
   An FCA rule since 2023 requiring firms to deliver good outcomes for retail customers, including fair value, clear communication and suitable products.

10. **Why is retention as important as winning new business?**
    Fees recur every year a client stays, and new mandates take months to win. Each lost client must be replaced just to stand still, so servicing protects the revenue base.

Continue to Sales →

C

Sales

The function that turns a product into revenue by finding customers, understanding what they need, persuading them to buy and keeping them coming back. Around 1 in 6 UK employees work in sales-related roles. The Sales workstream can place you in technology, consumer goods, business services, media, telecoms or financial services.

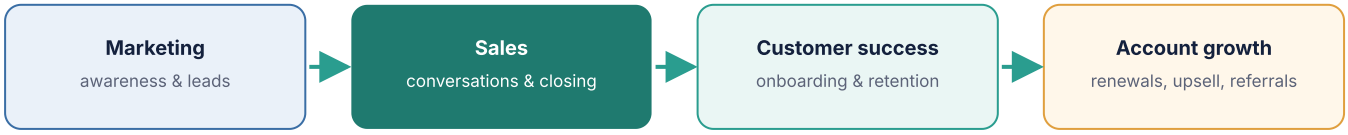
1. What sales is
2. The four parts
3. The sales process
4. Methodologies
5. How it makes money
6. Sales by industry
7. Tools, careers, trends
8. Glossary
9. Expert check

C1 · What sales is, and the types of selling

Sales is the part of a business responsible for **generating revenue**: identifying who might buy, understanding their problem, showing how the product solves it, agreeing a price, closing the deal, and growing the relationship.

ZERO-KNOWLEDGE EXPLAINER

Sales vs marketing: marketing creates awareness and interest across many people at once (adverts, content, campaigns). **Sales** converts that interest into actual customers, usually through one-to-one conversations. Marketing fills the top of the funnel; sales closes it. In modern companies they work as one "revenue" team.



The customer journey. Revenue Operations ("RevOps") ties all four stages together with shared data.

The main types of selling

Type	What it means	Example
B2B vs B2C	Selling to organisations vs individuals (A4)	Software to a bank vs a phone contract to you
Transactional	Simple, quick, price-driven, often one-off	Retail, basic subscriptions
Consultative / solution	Diagnose the client's problem first, then tailor a solution. Long cycles and high value.	Enterprise software, institutional asset management, consulting
Inside sales	Selling remotely by phone, email and video	Most tech SDR and AE roles
Field / outside sales	Meeting clients in person, often regionally	Medical devices, wholesale fund sales, FMCG
Hunter vs farmer	Hunters win new clients; farmers grow existing ones	New business AE vs account manager
Channel / partner	Selling through resellers, distributors or intermediaries	Software via consultancies; funds via platforms
Key account management (KAM)	Dedicated teams for the few biggest customers	A food brand's team for Tesco

EXPERT INSIGHT

The modern view of sales: buyers now research online before talking to a salesperson. Studies often suggest B2B buyers are well over halfway through their decision before engaging. So the salesperson's value is no longer information; it is **insight**, **diagnosis** and **trust**. "Helping clients buy" rather than "pushing products" is the idea to show in your answer.

C2 · The four parts of a sales organisation

1 · Lead generation

- SDRs / BDRs
- Research target accounts
- Cold calls, emails, LinkedIn
- Qualify interest
- Book first meetings

Goal: fill the pipeline with qualified opportunities.
Measured by: meetings booked, qualified leads

2 · New business (closing)

- Account executives (AEs)
- Discovery meetings
- Demos & proposals
- Negotiation
- Closing

Goal: convert opportunities into customers.
Measured by: revenue closed vs quota, win rate

3 · Account management & customer success

- Account managers
- Customer success managers
- Onboarding
- Renewals
- Upsell / cross-sell

Goal: keep and grow customers.
Measured by: retention, churn, net revenue retention

4 · Sales operations & enablement

- CRM & data
- Forecasting
- Territories & pricing
- Commission plans
- Training

Goal: make the whole engine efficient.
Measured by: forecast accuracy, productivity

Sales leadership sits above all four: sales managers, regional heads, the VP of Sales and the Chief Revenue Officer (CRO). They set targets, hire, coach and forecast.

The roles in detail

Role	A typical day	Skills that matter most
SDR / BDR (sales or business development representative)	Researching companies; 50+ calls and emails; LinkedIn outreach; qualifying calls; booking meetings for AEs	Resilience, curiosity, concise writing, organisation
Account executive (AE)	Discovery calls; tailored demos; writing proposals; handling objections; negotiating terms; updating forecasts	Listening, questioning, business understanding, negotiation
Account manager / key account manager	Business reviews with clients; spotting new needs; renewals; resolving issues; coordinating internal teams	Relationship-building, problem-solving, commercial thinking
Customer success manager (CSM)	Onboarding new customers; training; tracking product usage; preventing churn	Empathy, product knowledge, proactivity
Sales operations analyst	CRM reporting; pipeline dashboards; territory planning; commission calculations	Excel/data, process thinking, accuracy
Sales engineer / solutions consultant	Technical demos and answers for complex products	Technical depth plus communication

What a sales intern typically does

Research
Build prospect lists, research target companies and decision-makers, and do market and competitor analysis

Support
Shadow calls and meetings, prepare pitch materials, update the CRM and draft follow-up emails

Analyse
Track sales performance, build pipeline reports and identify where deals are won or lost

EXPERT INSIGHT

Hunter vs farmer, and why farmers matter more than people think. In subscription businesses, most revenue each year comes from *existing* customers. A company with strong account management can grow even with modest new sales. Saying you're drawn to **long-term relationships and account growth**, not just "closing deals", shows commercial maturity.

C3 · The sales process, step by step

Every structured sales team follows a version of this. Each stage has a clear exit criterion before a deal moves on in the CRM.

1 · Prospect
Identify target companies and people who fit the **ideal customer profile (ICP)**

›

2 · Outreach
Contact them by call, email, LinkedIn or referral

›

3 · Qualify
Do they have a real need, budget, authority and timing?

›

4 · Discovery
Deep questions: what problem, what impact, what success looks like

›

5 · Solution
Demo or presentation tailored to their problem

6 · Proposal
Written offer: scope, price, terms, business case

›

7 · Objections
Address concerns: price, timing, risk, competitors

›

8 · Negotiate
Agree on price, terms and contract length

›

9 · Close
Signed contract or purchase order

›

10 · Onboard & grow
Successful start, then renewal, upsell and referrals

Discovery: the most important stage

Great salespeople spend most of their time **asking and listening**, not presenting. Good discovery questions:

- "What prompted you to look at this now?"
- "How are you handling this today?"
- "What does that cost you, in time, money or risk?"
- "Who else is involved in this decision?"
- "What would success look like in 12 months?"
- "What's stopped you solving this before?"

Handling objections: a simple four-step technique

Listen
Let them finish; don't interrupt or argue

›

Acknowledge
"That's a fair concern..."

›

Explore
"Can you tell me more about what's behind that?"

›

Respond
Evidence, a case study or a reframe, then check: "Does that address it?"

Common objection	What it often really means	Good response direction
"It's too expensive."	Value isn't clear yet, or the budget is genuinely limited	Reconnect the price to the cost of the problem; explore options
"Now isn't a good time."	Low urgency or other priorities	Understand their timeline; agree on a next step
"We use a competitor."	Switching feels risky	Explore satisfaction gaps; reduce switching risk
"Send me some information."	A polite brush-off	Ask what specifically would be useful, and book a follow-up

EXPERT INSIGHT

"Sell me this pen", the classic interview test. The weak answer launches into the pen's features. The strong answer asks questions first: *"When did you last use a pen? What for? What frustrates you about the ones you have?"* Then it sells the specific benefit that matters to that person. It demonstrates discovery, which is what interviewers are actually testing.

C4 · Sales methodologies

A methodology is a structured way of selling. You don't need to master them, but knowing the names and ideas immediately marks you as someone who has done their homework.

Method	The core idea	How it works
BANT	A simple qualification check, originally from IBM	**B**udget, **A**uthority, **N**eed, **T**iming. If one is missing, the deal is at risk.
MEDDIC / MEDDPICC	Rigorous qualification for complex B2B deals	**M**etrics, **E**conomic buyer, **D**ecision criteria, **D**ecision process, (**P**aper process), **I**dentify pain, **C**hampion, (**C**ompetition)
SPIN Selling	Neil Rackham's research-based questioning model	**S**ituation → **P**roblem → **I**mplication → **N**eed-payoff questions, leading the buyer to state the value themselves
Challenger Sale	The best salespeople teach, tailor and take control	Bring a new insight that challenges how the customer thinks about their business
Solution selling	Sell the solution to a diagnosed problem, not the product	Diagnose pain → build a vision of the solution → prove value
Consultative selling	Act as a trusted adviser	Deep listening, honest advice (even "we're not right for you") and long-term focus
Value selling	Everything is framed in the customer's business outcomes	Quantify ROI: "this saves you £X / earns you £Y"

SPIN in action (an example)

Situation
"How does your team currently produce client reports?"

Problem
"Where does that process cause difficulties?"

Implication
"What happens when a report goes out late or wrong?"

Need-payoff
"How valuable would it be if that took half the time?"

The psychology of persuasion (Cialdini's principles)

Reciprocity: people return favours, so give value first (insight, help)

Commitment & consistency: small agreements lead to bigger ones

Social proof: "companies like yours use us" (case studies, references)

Authority: expertise and credentials build trust

Liking: we buy from people we like and relate to

Scarcity: limited availability increases value (used ethically)

Ethics matter. In regulated industries (financial services especially), pressure selling and misleading claims are illegal. Mis-selling scandals such as UK PPI cost banks tens of billions of pounds in compensation. The modern standard is selling **only what genuinely helps the customer**, which is also what builds repeat business.

EXPERT INSIGHT

If you can explain that **SPIN** and **consultative selling** are about helping the buyer discover the value themselves, and link that to your own experience of watching client conversations in asset management, you'll sound far more credible than someone who says "I'm persuasive and confident".

C5 · How sales makes money: the metrics

Revenue = **Leads** × **Conversion rate** × **Average deal size** × **Customer lifetime** (how long they stay)

Improve any one of these and revenue rises. That's why sales is so data-driven.

The sales funnel (illustrative B2B)



Each percentage is that stage's conversion rate. The overall conversion here is 0.6%.

Worked example: a software company

6 deals × £30,000 a year each = **£180k of new annual recurring revenue (ARR)**.

If customers stay 4 years on average: lifetime value = £120k each, so **£720k in total**.

If it cost £90k (salaries, tools, marketing) to win them, the acquisition cost is £15k per customer.

LTV : CAC = 120 : 15 = 8 : 1. Very healthy (above 3:1 is generally considered good).

The metrics every salesperson knows

Metric	Meaning	Why it matters
Pipeline	Total value of open opportunities	Future revenue visibility
Pipeline coverage	Pipeline ÷ target (aim ~3×)	Since most deals don't close, you need much more pipeline than target
Conversion / win rate	% of opportunities won	Shows sales skill and fit
Average deal size (ACV)	Average contract value	Bigger deals mean more revenue per effort
Sales cycle length	Days from first contact to close	Shorter cycles mean faster growth
Quota attainment	% of target achieved	The core measure of an individual
ARR / MRR	Annual / monthly recurring revenue	The key number in subscription businesses
Churn	% of customers or revenue lost in a period	A "leaky bucket" undermines growth
NRR (net revenue retention)	Revenue from existing customers this year ÷ last year, including upsell and churn	Above 100% means you grow even without new customers
CAC	Customer acquisition cost	Efficiency of sales and marketing spend
LTV / CLV	Customer lifetime value	How much a customer is worth over the relationship

How salespeople are paid

Usually **base salary + commission**, adding up to "OTE" (on-target earnings). A typical split is 50/50 or 60/40 base/variable. Commission might be a percentage of revenue closed, with **accelerators** (higher rates) above 100% of quota. That's why sales attracts competitive, target-motivated people. In **financial services**, pay is more salary-plus-bonus, because regulators discourage incentives that could lead to mis-selling.

EXPERT INSIGHT

Pricing models you should recognise: one-off purchase; subscription (per user or per month); usage-based (pay per use); tiered (good / better / best); and percentage of value (like asset management's % of AUM). The pricing model shapes how a sales team sells and how it's rewarded.

C6 · Sales across different industries

The Sales workstream could match you with very different businesses. The fundamentals are the same, but the shape differs:

Industry	What's sold, to whom	How it works	Key terms
Technology / SaaS	Software subscriptions to businesses	The SDR → AE → CSM model; recurring revenue; demos; free trials; highly metric-driven	ARR, churn, NRR, pipeline, demo
FMCG / consumer goods	Food, drink and household brands to retailers (Tesco, Sainsbury's, Amazon)	Key account managers negotiate shelf space, pricing and promotions with retailer buyers; data from till sales	Listings, ranging, promotions, category management, trade spend
Financial services	Funds, insurance, banking, payments, data to institutions and intermediaries	Consultative, regulated and relationship-driven; long cycles; compliance sign-off on materials	AUM, mandates, buy lists, brokers, Consumer Duty
Media & advertising	Advertising space and audiences to brands and agencies	Sell audiences and campaigns; negotiate with media agencies; data-driven targeting	CPM, reach, impressions, inventory, programmatic
Professional / B2B services	Consulting, legal, recruitment, facilities	Selling expertise and trust; proposals and pitches; partners often sell	Pitch, tender, retainer, utilisation
Telecoms & utilities	Connectivity, energy, contracts to homes and businesses	High-volume B2C plus enterprise B2B; contracts and renewals	Contract term, churn, ARPU
Medical / pharma	Devices and medicines to hospitals and the NHS	Highly regulated; technical; procurement frameworks	Formulary, tender, procurement
Recruitment	Hiring services to companies; roles to candidates	Two-sided sales (clients and candidates); fees as a % of salary	Placement fee, retained vs contingent search

Bridge: asset management distribution is consultative B2B sales

Sales concept	How it shows up in asset management
Ideal customer profile	Pension schemes of a certain size, or wealth managers with matching investment styles
Lead generation	Consultant relationships, conferences, research-led content
Qualification	Is there a live manager search? Do we fit the criteria?
Proposal	The RFP / DDQ
Demo / pitch	The finals presentation to trustees
Multiple decision-makers	Trustees, the investment committee, the consultant, the sponsoring employer
Account management	Client relationship managers, quarterly reviews
Recurring revenue and churn	Annual management fees and mandate losses

EXPERT INSIGHT

This table is your most powerful tool for the Sales answer. You can say truthfully that you've watched high-value consultative B2B sales up close, with long cycles, many stakeholders and recurring revenue that depends on retention, **using sales language** that a software or consumer-goods reader will instantly recognise.

C7 · Tools, careers and trends

The tools

Category	Examples	Used for
CRM	Salesforce, HubSpot, Microsoft Dynamics	Recording every contact, opportunity and deal stage. The "single source of truth".
Prospecting & data	LinkedIn Sales Navigator, ZoomInfo, Apollo	Finding target companies and contacts
Sales engagement	Outreach, Salesloft	Automated, personalised email and call sequences
Conversation intelligence	Gong, Chorus	Recording and analysing calls with AI for coaching
Proposals & e-signature	PandaDoc, DocuSign	Sending proposals and signing contracts

The career ladder

Intern / graduate
Learn the product and process

›

SDR / BDR
Typically 12–18 months

›

Account executive
Own a quota and close deals

›

Senior / enterprise AE or account director
Bigger, more complex clients

›

Sales manager → VP Sales → CRO
Lead teams and strategy

Sales is one of the most transferable skill sets in business. Many CEOs started in sales, and the skills carry straight into asset management distribution, consulting, recruitment and entrepreneurship.

Trends to know

1 · AI across the sales cycle. AI drafts outreach, researches prospects, summarises calls and forecasts deals. Some firms use "AI SDRs" for first-touch outreach, so human value shifts to complex conversations, relationships and judgement.

2 · The informed buyer. Buyers research independently and talk to sales later. Salespeople must add insight beyond what's online, which explains the rise of consultative and "Challenger" approaches.

3 · Product-led growth (PLG). Users try a product free and upgrade themselves (e.g. Slack, Canva). Sales then focuses on expanding usage within companies.

4 · Customer success and retention. In subscription businesses, keeping and expanding customers drives most growth. Net revenue retention is now a headline metric.

5 · Social selling. Building credibility on LinkedIn through content and networks before ever making contact.

6 · Data-driven and RevOps. Marketing, sales and customer success are united under shared data and targets, so analytical skills are increasingly valued.

7 · Hybrid selling. A mix of video and in-person meetings. In-person is used deliberately for high-value moments.

8 · Ethics and trust. Regulation (e.g. Consumer Duty in finance) and buyer cynicism reward honest, long-term, value-based selling.

EXPERT INSIGHT

A strong one-sentence synthesis for your answer: *"As AI takes on more routine outreach and buyers arrive better informed, the value of a salesperson increasingly lies in understanding a client's problem deeply and building trust over time."*

C8 · Sales glossary

Account executive (AE): the salesperson who closes deals

Account management: looking after and growing existing clients

ACV: annual contract value

ARR / MRR: annual / monthly recurring revenue

B2B / B2C: selling to businesses / consumers

BANT: budget, authority, need, timing

CAC: customer acquisition cost

Champion: an internal supporter at the client who sells for you

Churn: customers or revenue lost

Close: the point where the customer commits

Cold outreach: contacting someone with no prior relationship

Commission: pay linked to sales achieved

CRM: customer relationship management system

Cross-sell: selling a different product to an existing client

Customer success: making sure customers get value and stay

Decision-maker / economic buyer: the person who controls the budget

Demo: a product demonstration

Discovery: questioning to understand the client's needs

Enablement: training and materials that help salespeople sell

Forecast: the prediction of what will close this period

Gatekeeper: a person who controls access to the decision-maker

ICP: ideal customer profile

Inbound / outbound: leads that come to you / that you chase

KAM: key account management

Lead / MQL / SQL: potential customer / marketing-qualified / sales-qualified

LTV / CLV: customer lifetime value

MEDDIC: a qualification framework for complex deals

NRR: net revenue retention

Objection: a concern raised by the buyer

OTE: on-target earnings (base + commission)

Pipeline: open opportunities and their value

Pipeline coverage: pipeline ÷ target

Procurement: the client's purchasing department

Prospect: a potential customer

Qualification: checking whether a lead is worth pursuing

Quota: the sales target

Renewal: a customer extending their contract

RevOps: revenue operations, aligning marketing, sales and success

RFP / tender: a formal request for proposals from a buyer

SDR / BDR: sales / business development representative

Sales cycle: the time from first contact to close

SPIN: situation, problem, implication, need-payoff

Stakeholder map: everyone involved in a buying decision

Territory: the region or client set a salesperson covers

Upsell: selling more or a premium version to an existing client

Value proposition: why the customer should buy from you

Win rate: % of opportunities won

Warm lead: a prospect who has already shown interest

C9 · Expert check: can you answer these out loud?

1. **What's the difference between sales and marketing?**
   Marketing creates awareness and interest across many people at once. Sales converts that interest into customers through one-to-one conversations, then helps retain and grow them.

2. **Walk me through a B2B sales process.**
   Prospect → outreach → qualify (e.g. BANT) → discovery → tailored solution → proposal → handle objections → negotiate → close → onboard → renew and expand.

3. **Why is discovery so important?**
   Because you can't sell value until you understand the buyer's problem and its impact. Good discovery lets the buyer articulate the need, which makes the solution compelling and the price justified.

4. **What does an SDR do vs an AE?**
   SDRs generate and qualify opportunities and book meetings. AEs run the sales process from discovery to close and own a revenue quota.

5. **What is churn, and why does it matter?**
   The rate at which customers or revenue are lost. High churn means you must keep replacing customers just to stand still, so retention and account management protect growth.

6. **What's pipeline coverage, and why aim for about 3×?**
   Pipeline value divided by target. Since only a fraction of deals close, you need several times your target in pipeline to hit it reliably.

7. **How would you handle "it's too expensive"?**
   Acknowledge it, explore what's behind it, reconnect the price to the value or the cost of the problem, consider options (scope, terms), and check that the concern is resolved.

8. **What is SPIN selling?**
   A questioning approach (Situation, Problem, Implication, Need-payoff) that helps buyers recognise the impact of their problem and the value of solving it themselves.

9. **How is AI changing sales?**
   It automates research, outreach and call analysis, so human value shifts towards complex conversations, judgement and long-term relationships.

10. **How does asset management distribution resemble B2B sales?**
    Long cycles, many decision-makers (trustees, consultants), formal proposals (RFPs), pitches, and recurring fee revenue that depends on retention, all handled by sales and relationship teams.

Continue to Public Relations →

D

Public Relations

The management of **reputation**: how an organisation or person is understood by the media, customers, investors, employees, politicians and the public. PR is mostly about **earned** attention, which you have to persuade people to give, rather than attention you pay for.

1. What PR is
2. Ecosystem & parts
3. How a campaign works
4. Media relations
5. Crisis communications
6. Corporate & financial PR
7. Business model & careers
8. Landscape & trends
9. Glossary
10. Expert check

D1 · What PR is (and isn't)

PR is the strategic management of communication between an organisation and the people who matter to it (its **stakeholders**), to build understanding, trust and reputation.

ZERO-KNOWLEDGE EXPLAINER

The simplest distinction: advertising is what you say about yourself in space you paid for. **PR** is getting *others*, such as journalists, experts, customers and influencers, to say it for you. Because it's third-party, it's more credible. Because you don't control it, it's harder.

	Advertising	Marketing	Public relations
Goal	Drive sales or awareness	Drive demand for products	Build reputation, trust and understanding
Audience	Customers	Customers	**All** stakeholders: media, investors, staff, government, communities, customers
Control	Full: you buy the space	High	Low: journalists decide what to write
Credibility	Lower ("they would say that")	Medium	Higher (third-party endorsement)
Includes bad news?	No	Rarely	**Yes**: crisis, issues, results, job cuts

The PESO model: the four types of media

Paid
Adverts, sponsored content, paid social, advertorials

Earned
Press coverage, interviews, reviews, awards. **The core of PR.**

Shared
Social media, influencers, word of mouth, reposts

Owned
Website, blog, reports, newsletters, the company's own channels

Modern PR works across all four ("integrated communications"). A research report (owned) can generate a news story (earned), be amplified on LinkedIn (shared) and be promoted with a paid boost (paid).

Why reputation is worth money

Customers pay more and stay loyal to brands they trust

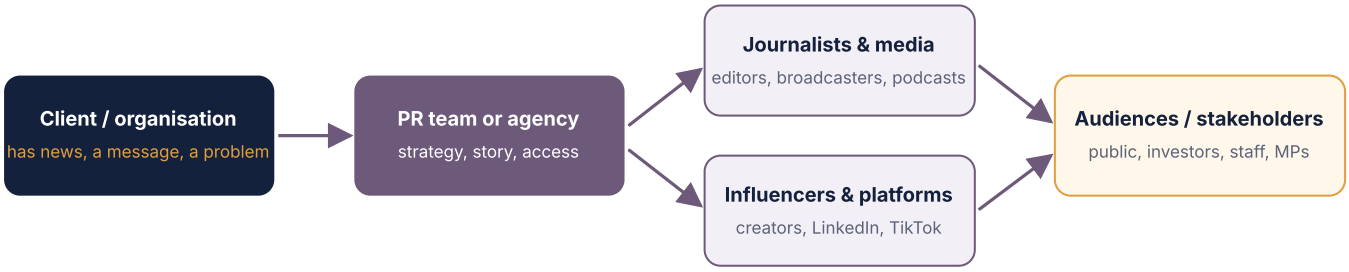
Investors value companies they understand and trust more highly, while scandals can wipe billions off share prices in a day

Employees, regulators and government: a good reputation attracts talent, eases regulation and earns a "licence to operate"

EXPERT INSIGHT

Warren Buffett's line is quoted constantly in PR: *"It takes 20 years to build a reputation and five minutes to ruin it."* Reputation is an **intangible asset**: you can't see it on a balance sheet, but it shows up in sales, share prices and hiring. PR people see themselves as its guardians. Framing PR as **protecting and growing a valuable asset**, not just "getting press", is the expert view.

D2 · The ecosystem and the parts of PR



The main parts (disciplines) of PR

Discipline	What it covers	Typical clients / examples
Corporate & financial	Reputation of the company itself; results announcements; M&A; IPOs; investor relations; CEO profile; ESG reporting	Listed companies, banks, asset managers, private equity (D6)
Consumer & brand	Getting products and brands talked about: launches, stunts, campaigns, influencers, events	Food and drink, fashion, beauty, retail, travel, entertainment
Crisis & issues management	Preparing for and responding to scandals, accidents, data breaches, lawsuits and product recalls	Any organisation, often at high hourly rates (D5)
Public affairs	Influencing policy and regulation: engaging MPs, civil servants, regulators and think tanks. Often called lobbying.	Energy, tech, finance, healthcare, trade bodies
Internal communications	Communicating with employees: strategy, change, restructuring, culture	Large employers, especially during change
Digital, social & influencer	Social media strategy, content, creator partnerships, online reputation	Consumer brands, increasingly B2B
Specialist sectors	Technology PR, healthcare PR, B2B PR, charity and campaigning	Specialist agencies and teams
Reputation & litigation	Protecting individuals and companies during legal disputes	High-profile individuals, companies in court

Agency side

An agency serves multiple clients at once, so you get variety, fast learning and pace. Agencies range from global networks to small specialists. **Most PR internships are agency-side.**

In-house side

The communications team inside one organisation (a bank, a retailer, a charity, an asset manager), often called "Corporate Communications" or "Press Office". You go deeper on one organisation and get closer to senior decision-making.

D3 · How a PR campaign works

Good PR is strategic, not just "sending press releases". The standard planning model (often taught as **RACE** or **ROSIE**: research, objectives, strategy, implementation, evaluation) looks like this:

1 · Research
Situation, audience, media landscape, competitors, current perceptions

›

2 · Objectives
SMART goals: e.g. "raise awareness among UK DC pension decision-makers"

›

3 · Audiences
Who exactly must think, feel or do something different?

›

4 · Messages
The 3–4 key messages and the proof points behind each

›

5 · Tactics
Press releases, interviews, research, events, social, influencers

›

6 · Implement
Timeline, media pitching, spokespeople, content

›

7 · Evaluate
Outputs → outcomes → business impact

Key messages and the message house



How PR is measured

Level	What's measured	Examples
Outputs	What you produced and got	Number of articles, reach, share of voice, key message pick-up
Outtakes	What the audience took from it	Engagement, recall, understanding
Outcomes	Changes in attitude or behaviour	Trust scores, consideration, sign-ups, enquiries
Impact	Business results	Sales, recruitment, share price stability, policy change

EXPERT INSIGHT

The Barcelona Principles (from AMEC, the measurement industry body) say PR should be measured by outcomes and impact, not just volume, and they reject **AVEs** (advertising value equivalents, "this coverage would have cost £X as an advert") as a measure of value. Knowing this shows you understand the profession's standards, not just its activities.

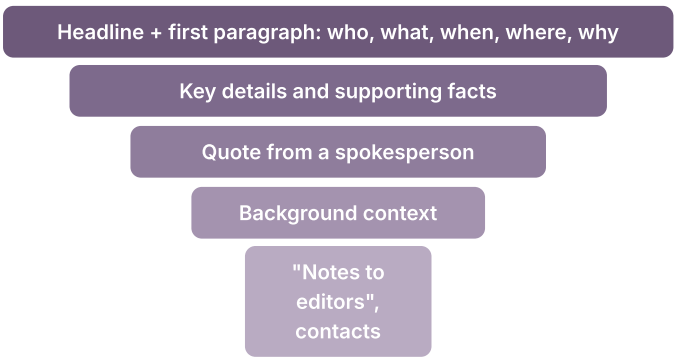
D4 · Media relations: how news works

To get coverage you must understand journalists: what they need, and what makes something **news**.

News values: what makes a story

New Genuinely new information	**Relevant** Matters to that outlet's readers	**Timely** Linked to what's happening now	**Data** Original numbers and research
Human Real people and real stories	**Conflict / surprise** Tension or the unexpected	**Prominence** Well-known people or brands	**Exclusivity** "First" or "only here"

The press release: inverted pyramid



Journalists read the top and decide in seconds, and editors cut from the bottom. So the most important information goes **first**.

Notes to editors hold background facts and a short company description (the **boilerplate**).

An **embargo** means "you can't publish until this date and time". It's used to give journalists time to prepare.

Media relations vocabulary

Pitch: a short, tailored email selling a story idea to a specific journalist

On the record: everything can be quoted and attributed

Spokesperson: the person authorised to speak for the organisation

Bridging: moving from a difficult question to a key message ("What's important here is...")

Newsjacking: linking your expert commentary to a breaking news story

Wire service: a distribution service for press releases (e.g. PA Media, Business Wire)

Exclusive: giving one outlet a story first, in exchange for better coverage

Off the record / background: information not to be quoted or attributed (terms must be agreed beforehand)

Media training: preparing spokespeople for interviews (staying on message, handling tough questions)

Media list: a targeted list of relevant journalists and their interests

Forward features: magazines' planned future topics, which create pitching opportunities

Coverage report: a summary of what was published, where, reach and tone

Types of media

National (BBC, FT, The Times, Guardian, Sky), **regional** (Manchester Evening News), **trade / B2B** (specialist titles for one industry, e.g. Citywire, Investment Week and Professional Pensions for asset management; PRWeek for PR), **broadcast** (TV and radio), **online-only** and **podcasts**, and **creators/influencers**.

EXPERT INSIGHT

The relationship is give-and-take. Journalists are under enormous time pressure, with fewer of them covering more topics. PR people who reliably provide **accurate information, good spokespeople, data and fast responses** become trusted sources. Those who spam irrelevant press releases get ignored. "Thinking like a journalist" is the core PR skill.

D5 · Crisis communications

A **crisis** is an event that threatens an organisation's reputation, operations or finances and demands urgent communication. An **issue** is a slower-burning problem that could become a crisis if ignored.

1 · Prepare
Crisis plan, scenarios, holding statements, a trained team, a "dark site"

›

2 · Respond fast
First statement within the "golden hour": acknowledge, show concern, commit to action

›

3 · Manage
Regular updates, one voice, all stakeholders (staff, customers, regulators, media)

›

4 · Recover
Fix the cause, show change, rebuild trust over time

›

5 · Learn
A review: what worked, what to change

The principles

Speed: a silence gets filled by others, often with speculation

Empathy first: show you care about the people affected before defending the organisation

Honesty: never lie or speculate. Say what you know, what you don't and when you'll update.

Responsibility: take ownership where appropriate; deflecting blame backfires

Consistency: one agreed message across every channel and spokesperson

Action: words must be backed by visible actions

Holding statement: a short, pre-prepared first response. *"We are aware of [situation]. Our immediate priority is [the safety/wellbeing of those affected]. We are working urgently to understand what happened and will provide a further update by [time]."*

Case studies every PR candidate should know

Case	What happened	Lesson
KFC "FCK" (UK, 2018)	A delivery-supplier change left hundreds of restaurants without chicken. KFC ran a full-page apology ad with its bucket spelling "FCK", humorous and humble.	Owning a mistake with honesty and personality can *improve* reputation. Now a widely awarded campaign.
BP Deepwater Horizon (2010)	A huge Gulf of Mexico oil spill. The CEO's remark "I'd like my life back" caused outrage.	Empathy for victims must come first. One careless quote can define a crisis.
Woodford fund suspension (2019)	A star UK fund manager's flagship fund froze withdrawals, trapping investors. Then the business collapsed.	In finance, reputation is the product. Loss of trust becomes loss of assets almost immediately.
Johnson & Johnson Tylenol (1982)	Poisoned capsules killed seven people in Chicago. J&J recalled 31 million bottles at once and introduced tamper-proof packaging.	The textbook "public safety before profit" response, which restored trust.

EXPERT INSIGHT

In the social media era the "golden hour" is often minutes, and employees, customers and creators may break the story before the press does. Modern crisis teams monitor social channels 24/7 and coordinate legal, HR, operations and comms together. If you mention crisis work in your answer, emphasise **calm judgement under pressure** and **clear, honest writing at speed**.

D6 · Corporate & financial PR

This is the specialism closest to your asset-management experience, and one of the best-paid parts of the industry. **Financial PR** manages how listed companies, banks, investors and deals are seen by the City, the financial media and shareholders.

Activity	What happens
Results announcements	Listed companies publish results (annual and half-year) via the **RNS** (the London Stock Exchange's Regulatory News Service) at 7:00am. Financial PR drafts the messages, briefs journalists, arranges CEO and CFO interviews, and monitors the reaction.
M&A (mergers & acquisitions)	Handling communications for takeovers, including hostile bids. Timing is governed by the **Takeover Code**, and leaks can move share prices.
IPOs	Building the story for a company listing on the stock exchange, and coordinating with banks and lawyers
Investor relations (IR) support	Communicating strategy to shareholders and analysts; annual reports; capital markets days
Activism & special situations	Defending (or advising) when activist investors campaign for change at a company
Restructuring & crisis	Profit warnings, debt problems, leadership exits, regulatory investigations

Regulation applies here too. Under UK **MAR** (Market Abuse Regulation), "inside information" that could move a share price must be announced properly via the RNS and not leaked selectively. Financial PR people work under strict confidentiality and are often put on "insider lists".

PR for asset managers: your bridge

What asset managers want from PR

- Fund managers quoted as experts in the **FT, Bloomberg, Reuters, The Times** and on broadcast
- Coverage in **trade press**: Citywire, Investment Week, Money Marketing, FT Adviser, Professional Pensions, Pensions & Investments, IPE
- **Thought leadership**: market outlooks, research reports and commentary that build credibility with institutional clients
- Fund launches, awards and senior hires
- Crisis management: underperformance, fund closures, regulatory issues

Why it matters commercially

- Consultants, fund selectors and trustees read the trade press, so media visibility supports **distribution**
- Expert commentary builds the "brand" of individual fund managers
- All marketing must comply with FCA financial promotions rules
- Trust is the product: a reputational hit can trigger **outflows**, i.e. lost revenue

EXPERT INSIGHT

The UK financial and corporate PR firms to know (orientation only, not a 10K host list): Brunswick, FGS Global, Teneo, Headland, Lansons, Instinctif Partners, Citigate Dewe Rogerson, Powerscourt, Camarco, H/Advisors Maitland, Montfort (which provides PR support to the 10,000 Interns Foundation). Many asset managers also have strong in-house press teams.

D7 · How PR makes money, and careers

Agency business model

An agency sells **people's time and expertise**.

- **Retainer:** a fixed monthly fee for ongoing work (from a few thousand pounds a month for a small client to £50k+ for large corporates)
- **Project fee:** a one-off campaign, launch or deal
- **Hourly / day rates:** especially for crisis and financial work, with senior advisers billing high rates
- **Success fees** (sometimes): e.g. on completed deals

The agency economics

Profit = **Fee income** − **Staff costs** (~50–60%+) − **Overheads**

- **Utilisation:** the % of staff time that's billable. The key efficiency metric.
- **Client retention:** losing a big retainer hurts badly
- **New business:** agencies win clients through **pitches**, which is sales again (C3)

In-house: the communications team is a **cost centre** (A1) funded from the company's budget. It proves value through coverage quality, reputation and trust scores, crises avoided, and support for sales, recruitment and investor confidence. In-house teams often hire and manage agencies.

The career ladder

Agency title	Typical responsibility	In-house equivalent
Intern / Graduate trainee	Media monitoring, research, media lists, coverage reports, drafting	Comms assistant
Account Executive (AE)	Drafting releases, pitching journalists, managing day-to-day tasks	Press officer
Senior AE / Account Manager	Running campaigns, client contact, managing juniors	Communications manager
Account Director / Associate Director	Owning client relationships and strategy; budgets	Head of communications
Director / Partner / MD	Senior counsel to CEOs, new business, running the agency	Communications director / CCO

A day as a PR intern

08:00 Media monitoring: summarise overnight news about clients and their sectors › **09:30** Team meeting: priorities, news hooks › **10:30** Build media lists; research journalists › **13:00** Draft a press release, social posts or a briefing note › **15:00** Help with an event, interview or client call › **17:00** Coverage report: what landed, where, tone

Professional bodies

CIPR (Chartered Institute of Public Relations) and **PRCA** (Public Relations and Communications Association) are the UK professional bodies. They run qualifications, ethics codes and the annual industry census. **PRWeek** is the industry's trade publication. Reading it for a few weeks before your application gives you current examples to mention.

D8 · Landscape and trends

Types of UK PR firm

Type	Description	Examples (orientation only)
Global networks	Large, multi-discipline, often owned by advertising groups (WPP, Omnicom, IPG, Publicis)	Edelman (independent), Weber Shandwick, Burson (formed 2024 from BCW and Hill & Knowlton), FleishmanHillard, Ketchum
Corporate & financial specialists	City-focused: results, deals, crisis, reputation	Brunswick, FGS Global, Teneo, Headland, Lansons, Instinctif, Powerscourt
UK agencies & consumer specialists	Creative consumer and brand work, or broad UK agencies	Freuds, MHP Group, Hope&Glory, Hotwire (tech)
Public affairs	Policy, government and regulatory engagement	Hanover, Portland, Cicero, WA Communications

Trends to know

1 · AI and "AI search". People increasingly get answers from AI chatbots. PR is asked how brands appear in AI answers (**GEO**, generative engine optimisation), and credible earned media matters more because AI draws on trusted sources.

2 · Misinformation and deepfakes. Fake images, audio and video can spark a crisis in minutes, so monitoring and rapid verification are essential.

3 · The creator economy. Influencers and creators (TikTok, YouTube, LinkedIn) rival traditional media for reach, especially with younger audiences. ASA rules require clear labelling (#ad).

4 · Shrinking newsrooms. Fewer journalists covering more ground. PR must provide ready-to-use, accurate, data-led stories, and owned channels matter more.

5 · Greenwashing scrutiny. The CMA's Green Claims Code, ASA rulings and the FCA anti-greenwashing rule mean sustainability claims must be evidenced. PR teams now work closely with legal and compliance.

6 · Purpose and polarisation. Brands face pressure to take positions on social issues, and risk backlash from both sides. Knowing when to speak is a judgement call.

7 · Measurement and data. Clients demand proof of impact (D3). Analytics and social listening tools are standard.

8 · Executive visibility. CEOs and leaders building profiles on LinkedIn and podcasts. "Thought leadership" is a growing service, especially in B2B and finance.

EXPERT INSIGHT

A one-sentence synthesis for your answer: *"As AI tools and social platforms reshape how people find information, and misinformation spreads faster than ever, credible, well-evidenced communication has become one of the most valuable things an organisation can invest in."*

D9 · PR glossary

Account Executive: an entry-level agency role

AVE: advertising value equivalent (discredited measure)

Boilerplate: the standard "about us" paragraph

Brief: a client's description of what they want

CIPR / PRCA: UK professional bodies

Crisis comms: communication during an emergency

Earned media: coverage you didn't pay for

Exclusive: a story given to one outlet first

Holding statement: a first, short crisis response

Internal comms: communication with employees

Key messages: the core points you want remembered

Media list: a targeted list of journalists

Media training: preparing spokespeople for interviews

Newsjacking: tying commentary to breaking news

Owned media: your own channels

Pitch: a story idea sent to a journalist (or an agency's bid to win a client)

Reach / impressions: potential audience size / times seen

Retainer: an ongoing monthly agency fee

Sentiment: the tone of coverage (positive, neutral, negative)

Social listening: monitoring online conversation

Stakeholder: anyone affected by or affecting the organisation

Trade press: specialist industry publications

Wire service: a press-release distribution network

AMEC: the international measurement body

Barcelona Principles: PR measurement standards

Bridging: moving from a question to a key message

Byline / op-ed: an article written under an executive's name

Coverage: media articles or mentions achieved

Dark site: a pre-built crisis webpage, published if needed

Embargo: a publication restriction until a set time

Financial PR: communications for listed companies and deals

Influencer / creator: an individual with an online audience

Issues management: handling problems before they become crises

Lobbying / public affairs: influencing policymakers

Media monitoring: tracking coverage and news

Message house: a framework for structuring messages

Off / on the record: unattributable / quotable

PESO: paid, earned, shared, owned

Press release: a formal news announcement

Reputation management: protecting and building how you're seen

RNS: the LSE Regulatory News Service (financial announcements)

Share of voice: your coverage vs competitors'

Spokesperson: the authorised voice of the organisation

Thought leadership: positioning leaders as expert voices

Utilisation: billable share of agency time

D10 · Expert check: can you answer these out loud?

1. **What's the difference between PR, marketing and advertising?**
   Advertising is paid space you control. Marketing drives product demand. PR manages reputation with all stakeholders, mainly through earned, third-party coverage you don't control but which carries more credibility.

2. **What is the PESO model?**
   Paid, Earned, Shared and Owned media. Modern campaigns integrate all four, with earned media at PR's core.

3. **What makes a story newsworthy?**
   It's new, relevant to that audience, timely, backed by data or human stories, and has prominence, surprise or exclusivity.

4. **How would you structure a press release?**
   An inverted pyramid: headline and a first paragraph answering who, what, when, where and why; then supporting details, a spokesperson quote, background, and notes to editors with the boilerplate and contacts.

5. **What are the first steps in a crisis?**
   Establish the facts, issue a holding statement quickly showing empathy and action, align all spokespeople, update stakeholders regularly, and back words with action.

6. **Give an example of good crisis handling.**
   E.g. KFC's 2018 "FCK" apology: honest, humble and on-brand, which turned a supply failure into a widely praised campaign.

7. **How should PR be measured?**
   Beyond volume, by outcomes and business impact (the Barcelona Principles), such as message pick-up, share of voice, trust and behaviour change, not AVEs.

8. **What does financial PR involve?**
   Communications for listed companies and financial firms: results via the RNS, M&A, IPOs, investor relations and crisis, all under market-abuse rules on inside information.

9. **How does a PR agency make money?**
   Retainers, project fees and hourly rates for expert time. Profitability depends on utilisation, client retention and winning new business through pitches.

10. **Name a trend changing PR.**
    E.g. AI-driven search and misinformation: credible earned media becomes more valuable because AI tools draw on trusted sources, and false content can spread in minutes.

Continue to Bringing it together →

E

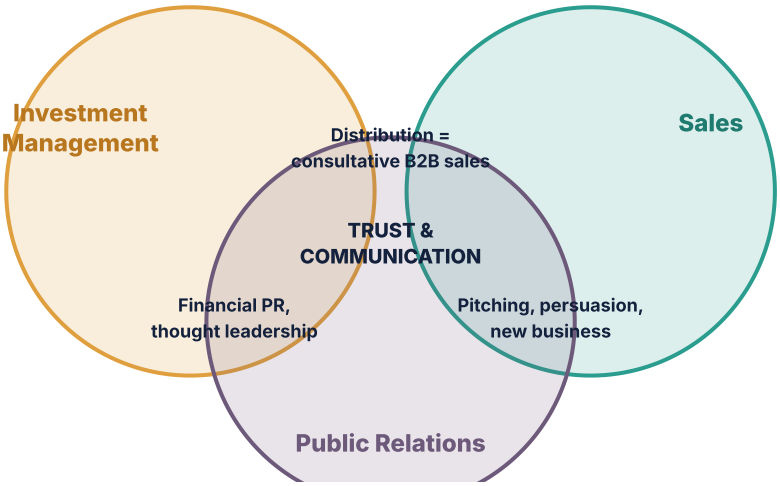
Bringing it together

How your three industries connect, and how to turn this knowledge into three 250-word answers that show you understand what you're applying to.

1. How the three industries connect
2. Turning knowledge into your 250 words

E1 · How the three industries connect

Your choices aren't random. Investment management depends on both sales and PR. Seeing these links helps you understand each industry, but **each answer must still stand alone**, because each will be read by a different firm.



Shared skill	In Investment Management	In Sales	In PR
Understanding the audience	Knowing what a pension trustee vs a wealth manager needs	Discovery: diagnosing the buyer's problem	Stakeholder mapping; knowing what a journalist needs
Clear, accurate communication	Explaining performance; compliant materials	Proposals, pitches and follow-ups	Press releases, key messages, statements
Building trust over time	Client retention over years	Account management and renewals	Media relationships and reputation
Commercial awareness	AUM × fees; net flows	Pipeline, conversion, retention	Retainers, utilisation; reputation as an asset
Working under pressure	Market falls, client deadlines	Targets and quarter-end	Breaking news and crises

EXPERT INSIGHT

Your personal thread: *"In every one of these industries, success depends on understanding an audience and earning its trust."* Use that idea in your head to stay consistent across the three answers. But never mention your other choices in an answer, and make each one specific to its own industry's language and economics.

E2 · Turning knowledge into your 250 words

You don't win by showing *all* of this knowledge. You win by showing the **right two or three pieces, used precisely**. Over-stuffing jargon reads as a glossary, not understanding. Use the playbook's five-part structure (hook → understanding → evidence → contribution → close), and pick from these:

	Investment Management	Sales	Public Relations
Insight for your hook	Inflation erodes cash; asset managers decide whether millions retire comfortably (A2, B1)	Buyers arrive informed, so a salesperson's value is diagnosis and trust (C1)	Reputation is an intangible asset that takes years to build and minutes to lose (D1)
How it makes money	Fees on AUM; growth from performance plus net flows; retention (B10)	Pipeline × conversion × deal size × retention; churn (C5)	Agencies: retainers and utilisation. In-house: protecting value (D7)
A live trend (pick one)	Fee compression; pension consolidation; private markets (B13)	AI in sales; retention and NRR (C7)	AI search and misinformation; greenwashing scrutiny (D8)
2–3 terms to use correctly	assets under management, distribution, client retention, institutional / wholesale	discovery, pipeline, account management, consultative	earned media, key messages, stakeholders, media relations
Your evidence angle	What you did in your AM role and what it taught you about clients	The AM sales cycle in sales language, plus a non-finance persuasion example	How carefully an investment firm communicates, plus a writing example

Before and after: what this knowledge does to a sentence

Before
"I am interested in investment management because I enjoy finance and markets."

After
"Because an asset manager's revenue rises and falls with the assets it keeps, I saw that client trust matters as much as returns."

Before
"I am a confident and persuasive person who would be good at sales."

After
"The best salespeople I've watched spent most of each meeting asking questions, because a client who articulates their own problem is halfway to buying."

Before
"I want to work in PR because I enjoy writing and social media."

After
"Earned coverage carries a credibility that advertising can't buy, which is why the skill of turning an organisation's goals into a story a journalist wants is so valuable."

Final self-test before you write

- ☐ I can explain each industry's **four parts** in one breath
- ☐ I can explain **how each makes money** in one sentence
- ☐ I can name **one live trend** for each, and why it matters
- ☐ I have answered every **Expert check** out loud
- ☐ I know which **2–3 terms** I'll use in each answer, and use them correctly
- ☐ Each answer has a **true, specific story** from my own experience

Notes on sources and accuracy: programme facts come from the 10,000 Interns Foundation. Industry figures (UK AUM of about £9trn per the Investment Association; fee ranges; funnel, P&L and retainer examples) are rounded or illustrative and meant for understanding, not quotation. Firm names are examples for orientation, not a list of 10,000 Black Interns hosts. Regulatory and policy points reflect the position as at October 2026 and may change.

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